



PANKAJ TIWARI

(FROM LEFT) JYOTIRADITYA SCINDIA, DIGVIJAY SINGH AND SURESH PACHAURI; KAMAL NATH



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The Congress "leadership summit" was meant to showcase a united Congress, but leaders ended up taking on each other.

infighting that started in August at the Chhindwara 'unity summit' when a section of the party led by AICC General Secretary Digvijay Singh sought to project Union Commerce Minister Kamal Nath as its chief ministerial candidate. By the time Congress final list of candidates was out, it was clear that at least 40 candidates owed their tickets to factional bosses, and not their ability to win. The feuds cost the party dear. In the respective turfs of leaders like Nath in Mahakoshal, Pachauri in Bhopal-Hoshangabad, Union Minister of State for IT and Telecom Jyotiraditya Scindia in Gwalior-Chambal and Digvijay Singh in Madhya Bharat and parts of Malwa, the Congress gained a few seats, but the numbers were not sufficient to halt the BJP juggernaut. Several of the Congress's old warhorses lost their seats including former deputy chief minister Subhash Yadav, former speaker Srinivas Tiwari and former deputy speaker of the assembly Hazarilal Raghuvanshi.

The Congress, of course, will begin to pick up the pieces for the next round, but the same cannot be said of Uma Bharati, the BJP rebel and former chief minister of the state, who put her own reputation on the line in her home district Tikamgarh and lost by over 9,000 votes to Yadavendra Singh of the Congress. That must have been particularly galling for the former *sanyasin* whose mission in life, after her bitter breakup with the BJP, was to play spoilsport and sabotage

the saffron party's candidates in as many constituencies as possible. Her outfit Bharatiya Jan Shakti did manage to win five seats. But time is not on her side and her political future appears rather bleak now.

While Bharati's rhetoric had lost its bite for a while, it was the BSP's performance that deflated the Dalit outfit's high hopes from Madhya Pradesh. From all available indications, its new-fangled social engineering of combining its traditional Dalit vote with upper caste leaders, especially Brahmins, has failed to deliver the expected results. The BSP managed to grow its tally from two in 2003 to seven in 2008, with its success confined to its traditional strongholds of Gwalior-Chambal and Vindhya region bordering Uttar Pradesh. Though Mayawati fielded candidates in all the seats in the state for the first time, its vote percentage hardly showed any rise, indicating that for the time being, it would have to contend with the role of a marginal player in Madhya Pradesh's electoral arena.

On the other hand, the BJP victory only brightens the party's prospects for the Lok Sabha elections in the summer of 2009 as it currently holds 24 out of the total of 29 constituencies in Madhya Pradesh. For the Congress, it is back to the drawing board. Since the 1991 elections, the party has invariably lost the parliamentary elections in the state, ceding an overwhelmingly large number of seats to the BJP. If it doesn't stem the rot urgently, the assembly election results are likely to be repeated in a few months' time when voters turn out to pick their MPs. ■